COUPLES WORKSHEETS · VOLUME I

Values & Compatibility

A Clinical Workbook for Couples — Five session-ready worksheets for couples

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How to Use This Workbook

> CLINICIAN NOTE
>
> These five worksheets are designed to be sequenced across 3–5 sessions, though each can stand alone. They move from individual self-knowledge outward: what do I value → where do we align → where are we going → what can't bend → how do we work it out when we clash.

SUGGESTED SEQUENCING

Session 1 — Worksheet 1 (homework: complete individually before Session 2).

Session 2 — Compare Worksheet 1 results in-session; introduce Worksheet 2 as homework.

Session 3 — Process Worksheet 2; complete Worksheet 3 collaboratively in-session.

Session 4 — Worksheet 4 (do this one in-session; the stakes warrant a clinician in the room).

Session 5 — Worksheet 5, applied to a current or recent conflict.

INDICATIONS

Premarital counseling, relationship tune-ups, mixed-orientation and values-divergent couples, blended families negotiating identity and tradition, couples reconciling after rupture, couples considering major life transitions (children, relocation, career shift).

CONTRAINDICATIONS / CAUTIONS

Active intimate partner violence, untreated substance dependence, active affair not yet disclosed, severe untreated mental health crisis. Stabilize first.

CLINICAL FRAME

Emphasize throughout that compatibility is not sameness. The goal is not to discover that partners match on every item but to build a shared, honest map of where they align, where they differ, and which differences are workable versus which require genuine negotiation. Differences named are more workable than differences left implicit.

Worksheet 1

Core Values Identification & Prioritization

> **CLINICIAN NOTE**
>
> Complete this worksheet INDIVIDUALLY before comparing with your partner. The honesty of your own answers matters more than matching theirs. Expect the ranking exercise to feel uncomfortable — narrowing forces clarity, which is the clinical point. Bring the completed worksheet to your next session.

Partner A	Partner B
Date:	Session #:

STEP 1 — CIRCLE YOUR VALUES

Below is a list of values commonly named in relationships. Circle every value that resonates as genuinely important to YOU — not what you think you should value, and not what you value for your partner. Add any missing values in the blank spaces at the bottom.

☐ Achievement	☐ Adventure	☐ Authenticity	☐ Autonomy
☐ Balance	☐ Beauty	☐ Belonging	☐ Career
☐ Challenge	☐ Community	☐ Compassion	☐ Competence
☐ Connection	☐ Creativity	☐ Curiosity	☐ Dependability
☐ Discipline	☐ Education	☐ Empathy	☐ Equality
☐ Excellence	☐ Fairness	☐ Faith	☐ Family
☐ Financial security	☐ Flexibility	☐ Forgiveness	☐ Freedom
☐ Friendship	☐ Fun	☐ Generosity	☐ Growth
☐ Harmony	☐ Health	☐ Home	☐ Honesty
☐ Humor	☐ Independence	☐ Integrity	☐ Intimacy
☐ Justice	☐ Kindness	☐ Knowledge	☐ Leadership

☐ Learning	☐ Leisure	☐ Love	☐ Loyalty
☐ Openness	☐ Order	☐ Parenthood	☐ Partnership
☐ Peace	☐ Perseverance	☐ Physical fitness	☐ Play
☐ Power	☐ Recognition	☐ Respect	☐ Responsibility
☐ Romance	☐ Safety	☐ Self-respect	☐ Service
☐ Sexuality	☐ Simplicity	☐ Spirituality	☐ Stability
☐ Status	☐ Success	☐ Tradition	☐ Tradition of origin
☐ Trust	☐ Wealth	☐ Wisdom	☐ Work ethic

Additional values not listed:

STEP 2 — NARROW TO YOUR TOP 10

From everything you circled, choose the 10 values that matter most. Write them here in no particular order.

My Top 10 Values
1.
2.
3.
4.
5.
6.
7.
8.

9.
10.

STEP 3 — NARROW TO YOUR TOP 5 AND RANK THEM

From your Top 10, choose the 5 most important and rank them 1 (most important) through 5.

My Top 5 Values — Ranked
1.
2.
3.
4.
5.

Step 4 — The Hardest Question

If you had to choose ONE value as your north star — the one that organizes all the others — which is it?

Why this one?

STEP 5 — REFLECTION

1. Where did each of your top 5 values come from? (Family of origin, a formative experience, a person, a loss, a belief.)

2. Which of your top 5 values is hardest to live out in your current relationship, and why?

3. Which of your values do you suspect you and your partner share? Which do you suspect you differ on?

4. If your partner read only your top 5 list (no explanation), what might they misunderstand?

IN-SESSION PROCESSING (FOR CLINICIAN)

- Read your top 5 lists to one another without interrupting, explaining, or defending.
- Partner listening: reflect back ONLY what you heard, before reacting.
- Notice and name: overlaps, surprises, and silences.
- Reserve judgment about "right" values. The goal is accurate knowing, not alignment.

Worksheet 2

Values Alignment Grid

CLINICIAN NOTE

Each partner completes their own column pair (importance + satisfaction) first, then you compare. Importance = how much this domain matters to YOU. Alignment = how closely you and your partner agree on how this domain should be handled. Satisfaction = how it's actually going right now. A large gap between importance and satisfaction = a pressure point.

Partner A	Partner B
Date:	Session #:

SCORING KEY

1–3 = Low / minor 4–6 = Moderate 7–8 = High 9–10 = Core, non-negotiable territory

Life Domain	A: Importance to me (1–10)	B: Importance to me (1–10)	Current alignment (1–10)	Satisfaction (1–10)
Money & Finances				
Career & Ambition				
Family of Origin				
Children / Parenting (or child-free)				
Sexual & Physical Intimacy				
Emotional Intimacy & Communication				
Social Life & Friendships				

Life Domain	A: Importance to me (1–10)	B: Importance to me (1–10)	Current alignment (1–10)	Satisfaction (1–10)
Spirituality / Religion / Meaning				
Health, Fitness & Wellness				
Home Environment (order, aesthetic, routine)				
Leisure, Recreation & Fun				
Personal Growth & Autonomy				
Cultural, Civic & Political Values				
Conflict Style & Repair				

INTERPRETATION — WHAT THE GRID IS TELLING YOU

Once both partners have completed the grid, work through the prompts below together.

High-Importance Overlap — Your Shared Core

List the domains where BOTH partners scored 8 or higher on importance. These are the places where you must invest intentionally; when something matters this much to both of you, benign neglect becomes expensive fast.

Importance Mismatch — Hidden Friction

List domains with a gap of 4 points or more between partners' importance scores. These are places where one partner is carrying weight the other doesn't feel, or where one partner's investment is invisible to the other.

Alignment Gaps — Where You Disagree on How

List domains where alignment scored 5 or lower. These are not necessarily problems — they are places you haven't yet built a shared operating agreement.

High Importance + Low Satisfaction — Your Priority List

List domains where either partner rated importance 7+ AND satisfaction 5 or lower. This is your working list — the shortest path to felt improvement in the relationship.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

1. Which domain surprised you most when you saw your partner's score?

2. Is there a domain where you rated importance higher than you usually let on? What keeps that hidden?

3. Pick ONE domain from your priority list to focus on first. Why this one?

IN-SESSION PROCESSING (FOR CLINICIAN)

- Validate the emotion that arises around mismatch before problem-solving.
- Reframe low alignment as "an unwritten contract," not a character flaw.
- If one domain dominates the dysregulation (often sex, money, or in-laws), anchor the session there and defer the rest.

Worksheet 3

Future Vision Map

> CLINICIAN NOTE
>
> Complete this one INDIVIDUALLY, in writing, before sharing. The purpose is not to commit to any vision but to surface what each of you is quietly walking toward. Couples frequently discover that they've been traveling in parallel without realizing they are not headed to the same place — or that they are more aligned than their day-to-day friction suggests.

Partner A	Partner B
Date:	Session #:

INSTRUCTIONS

For each life domain, write a few words about what you hope — or expect — will be true at each time horizon. Write in concrete, specific terms (not "happy" but "in a smaller house closer to my mother, with one child in early elementary school"). Partner A writes in the "A:" space, Partner B in the "B:" space.

Life Domain	1 Year From Now	5 Years From Now	10 Years From Now
Where we live	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:
Work & career	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:
Family composition (children, pets, extended family involvement)	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:
Financial picture	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:

Life Domain	1 Year From Now	5 Years From Now	10 Years From Now
Lifestyle rhythm (pace, travel, hobbies)	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:
Our relationship — how it feels, what we do together	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:
Individual pursuits — who each of us is becoming	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:
Health & wellbeing	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:
Spiritual / meaning-making life	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:

THE COMPARISON CONVERSATION

After both partners have completed the grid, read each row aloud together. Look for three patterns:

Convergence

Rows where your visions point the same direction. These are places to celebrate and to protect.

Divergence

Rows where your visions point different directions. Name the divergence without immediately problem-solving. Which divergences are workable (a logistical negotiation) versus foundational (a values conflict requiring genuine work)?

Silence

Rows one or both of you couldn't answer. Silence is information. Is this a domain you've been avoiding? A domain you assumed was already decided? A domain that feels too scary to imagine?

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

1. What is the ONE thing on your 10-year vision that matters most to you?

2. Where in your partner's vision did you feel relief? Where did you feel tension in your body?

3. Is there a vision you stopped letting yourself imagine because you thought your partner wouldn't want it? Write it here:

4. What would need to be true in year 1 to make the 10-year vision possible?

IN-SESSION PROCESSING (FOR CLINICIAN)

• Track where visions diverge on high-stakes, time-sensitive items (children, relocation, career pivots). These cannot be deferred indefinitely.

• Name the difference between a values conflict and a preference conflict.

• If one partner's vision is notably sparse, explore — this often indicates depression, loss of agency, or long-standing accommodation.

Worksheet 4

Non-Negotiables & Flexibility Map

CLINICIAN NOTE

This worksheet is deliberately high-stakes. Complete it IN-SESSION with the clinician present. The goal is not to threaten the relationship but to create a clear, honest record of each partner's actual hard limits — so that accommodation and compromise happen in the right places, not the wrong ones. Couples who collapse their absolutes to preserve peace eventually pay that cost with resentment or rupture.

Partner A	Partner B
Date:	Session #:

INSTRUCTIONS

For each area, each partner writes a brief note in ONE of the three columns — whichever best captures where that item sits for you right now. You may feel pulled to soften an absolute. Resist that pull for the length of this exercise. You can revise later. You cannot hear your own truth if you filter it in the moment of writing.

Area	Absolute (I cannot be in a relationship without this / with this)	Strong preference (important, but I could adapt under the right conditions)	Flexible (I can work around this)
Monogamy / relationship structure	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:
Having children	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:
How children are raised	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:
Religion / spiritual practice	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:

Area	Absolute (I cannot be in a relationship without this / with this)	Strong preference (important, but I could adapt under the right conditions)	Flexible (I can work around this)
Geographic location	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:
Financial practices (debt, saving, risk)	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:
Career priority (whose, and how much)	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:
Role of extended family	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:
Substance use (alcohol, cannabis, other)	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:
Honesty & disclosure standards	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:
How conflict is handled	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:
Physical & sexual intimacy expectations	A: B:	A: B:	A: B:

REVIEWING THE MAP TOGETHER

1. Compatible Absolutes

List any areas where both partners named an absolute AND the absolutes are compatible (e.g., both absolute on monogamy, both absolute on no children).

2. Conflicting Absolutes

List any areas where both partners named an absolute AND the absolutes point in opposite directions. These are the most important conversations you will have. Some are resolvable with time, therapy, and creativity. Some are genuinely incompatible — and naming that clearly is a kindness, not a threat.

3. Asymmetric Weight

List areas where one partner has an absolute and the other has a flexible or preference rating. Asymmetric weight is common and usually workable, but it must be named — the flexible partner needs to understand what the absolute partner is carrying, and the absolute partner needs to understand they are asking for accommodation.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

1. Was there any item where you felt pressure — internal or from your partner — to downgrade an absolute to a preference? Name it:

2. Was there any item where you realized mid-exercise that something you'd called an absolute is actually flexible? Name it:

3. If your partner could not accommodate one of your absolutes, what would honesty require of you?

4. Is there a non-negotiable you've never said out loud because you were afraid of the conversation? Write it here:

IN-SESSION PROCESSING (FOR CLINICIAN)

• Do not allow premature reassurance. Let each partner sit with what they heard before anyone rushes to fix it.

• Distinguish "this is an absolute for me" from "this is an ultimatum to you." Absolutes describe self; ultimatums coerce other.

• Conflicting absolutes around children, monogamy, geography, and religion are common reasons couples discern toward dissolution — this is clinically valid and sometimes the healthiest outcome. Do not push toward reconciliation.

• If domestic violence, coercive control, or safety concerns surface, pivot to individual work.

Worksheet 5

When Values Collide: An Integration Exercise

CLINICIAN NOTE

This worksheet takes a CURRENT or RECENT conflict and locates the values underneath it. Most couples' conflicts are not really about the dishes, the text message, or the schedule — they are values collisions dressed in the clothing of logistics. Once partners can see the value each is protecting, the conflict often becomes workable in a way that argument could not make it.

Partner A	Partner B
Date:	Session #:

STEP 1 — NAME THE CONFLICT

The surface issue

Describe the situation as it appears on the outside — what happened, what was said or not said, what triggered the conflict. Stay descriptive, not interpretive.

STEP 2 — NAME THE VALUES UNDERNEATH

Each partner identifies what value of THEIR OWN they are protecting in this conflict. You are not describing what the other partner is violating. You are describing what you are defending in yourself.

Partner A — What I'm protecting

The value at stake for me here is…

Partner B — What I'm protecting

The value at stake for me here is…

STEP 3 — NAME THE FEAR UNDERNEATH THE VALUE

Every protected value has a fear attached. "I value honesty" often sits on top of "I'm afraid of being deceived the way I was before." Go one layer deeper.

Partner A — The fear underneath

If this value is not honored, I'm afraid that…

Partner B — The fear underneath

If this value is not honored, I'm afraid that…

STEP 4 — FIND THE SHARED HIGHER-ORDER VALUE

Almost every values collision contains, at a higher altitude, a value the couple actually shares. Two partners fighting over whether to spend the holidays with her family or his family both value family; they are arguing about whose, not whether. Locate yours.

The value we both hold

At a higher level, the value we both share in this conflict is…

STEP 5 — BRAINSTORM INTEGRATION (NOT COMPROMISE)

Compromise asks each partner to give up part of what they value. Integration asks: is there a solution that honors both values at once? Brainstorm freely here — you are not committing to any option, only generating possibilities. Stay in curiosity longer than feels comfortable. Most couples stop brainstorming just before the creative option appears.

Possible solutions that honor both values

List at least 5 options. Include options that sound impractical, expensive, or unconventional — they often unlock the workable one.

STEP 6 — CHOOSE AND COMMIT

Select one option (or combination of options) to try. Define what you will actually do, by when, and how you will know whether it worked.

What we will try

We will…

When we will review

We will check in on this by (date/occasion)…

How we will know it's working

We will know this is working because...

REFLECTION

1. What shifted when you named your OWN value instead of your partner's failure?

2. What shifted when you heard the fear underneath your partner's position?

3. Did you find a shared higher-order value? If not, what's the next conversation you need?

4. What pattern does this conflict fit into? Is this the first time, or a familiar loop?

IN-SESSION PROCESSING (FOR CLINICIAN)

• Slow the pace. Integration exercises fail when rushed. Let silence do the work.

• If one partner consistently cannot identify their own value (only their partner's violation), that is clinical information — likely externalization, difficulty with self-reflection, or protective stance. Work there.

• If no shared higher-order value can be located, consider whether the conflict is a genuine values incompatibility rather than a collision — some conflicts are not integrable and must be negotiated as ongoing difference, not solved.

• End the session by naming one small, concrete act each partner can do before the next session to honor the OTHER partner's named value.

End of Workbook

Prepared by KekeTheLPC • For licensed clinical use in couples therapy